



How we Test

The DMTRC: An information centre

When it comes to insights into digital products and technology, you should be able to bank upon the best. That's where the Digital Media Test & Research Centre (DMTRC) comes in. The DMTRC is the



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central testing resource for Digit, the place where we evaluate the latest in hardware, software and technology, as seen in the following sections. These tests and reviews are in accordance with the most cutting-edge evaluation processes and methodologies used around the world. All this is done to help you make a more calculated and informed choice on which product or technology to adopt.

Demystifying the ratings

The DMTRC brings you hardware and software product reviews in the Test Drive section of the magazine—as standalone

product reviews as well as comparison tests. We test an assortment of hardware and software products from the Indian market, and the evaluation processes involve parameters such as sheer performance, build quality, value for money and the features of the product. A set of weightages are applied to these evaluation parameters to arrive at an overall score. The table given below is used in applying the overall grades to these products based upon the overall scores.

In the case of the comparison tests, the weightages are applied to the various test parameters according to their importance. This is explained in the magazine articles and in the Test Process section of the CD, where the benchmarking methodology is explained in detail.

About our Awards

Digit rewards exceptional performance in each comparison test by picking a Best Performance winner. This award goes to the product that outshines the competition in our performance benchmarks. The Best Value award, on the other hand, is awarded to the product that we feel has the best combination of price and performance. Consider this your yardstick if you are looking for more value for your money.

VERDICTS				
A+ 20-19.5	A 19-17.5	A- 17-15.5	B+ 15-13.5	B 13-11.5
B- 11-9.5	C+ 9-7.5	C 7-5.5	C- <5	

STAR RATINGS	
★★★★★	Excellent: a brilliant combination of price, performance and features, far beyond expectations
★★★★	Good: a good buy, better than most products in its category
★★★	Average: reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product
★★	Mediocre: does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas
★	Poor: contains serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for the target application

In Test this Month

This month, we bring you the best of 15 processors in our first ever processor comparison. Among the processors tested are the formidable AMD Athlon XP processors, which are based upon a new Palomino core that uses the newly incorporated PR indexes of nomenclature.



We also got our hands on Intel's brand new 0.13 micron-based Pentium

III Tualatin processors, sporting higher clock speeds.

Of special interest amongst standalone tests in our Bazaar section (Page 68) is the Dell Precision 530 graphics workstation. We used advanced graphics and real-world rendering applications to put this machine through its paces.

What's new?

Beginning with this issue of Digit, we have moved to a new, more comprehensive set of tests and benchmarking methodologies that examine every nuance of the hardware and software. Up first, we used a total of 15 individual benchmarking suites and applications to evaluate the mettle of the processors under review.

Also new are detailed reviews of the winning products and some of the close contenders in the race for the top spot.



There's More on the CD

Due to space limitations, we carry full reviews of only the top few products in the magazine. You can find reviews of more products in the Test Drive section of our Mindware CD. This is accompanied by the detailed test and evaluation procedures used in the processor comparison test.